

Ask yourself a question: what has improved your quality of life more than your smartphone? If you're lucky, you said your parents or a close friend, but for most people their lives are shaped by the technology that is constantly at their fingertips. Those of us who were alive before the smartphone boom of the late aughts are keenly aware of how dramatically everyday life has changed since then. People feel lost without their phones; not being in constant contact with the entire world can easily trigger a complete meltdown. "Where's my phone?" has become a phrase that can instantly cause an entire room of people to check the safety of their own device, lest they become like the lost soul who is without theirs. Modern information technology has become a dominant force in the lives of every human being on the planet. It is no longer a niche hobby that is practiced by the geekiest among us; it is a necessary skill for navigating modern life. This is why, now more than ever, becoming technologically literate can profoundly improve your quality of life; it helps you make your technology work better for you, it saves you money, and it can even create opportunities to earn money as well. If you want to understand why technological literacy matters so much today, it helps to look at how it can directly improve the way you use the devices you rely on.

Whether you are using a desktop computer, a tablet, or a smart home thermostat, knowing how to properly use your device will make that device better, and having better devices means having an easier life. Bill Gates once said, "Never before in history has innovation offered promise of so much to so many in so short a time" (*Department of Commerce*, n.d.). That promise is wonderful, but it holds no value if one does not know how to properly utilize those innovations. Recent research supports the idea that tech skills are a gateway to well-being. A 2025 study published on ResearchGate found a distinct 'threshold effect,' where the positive impact of technology on life satisfaction only accelerates significantly once a user reaches a specific level of digital proficiency (Li et al., 2025). In other words, it's not enough to simply have the phone; you need to know how to use it. A smartphone can connect you to every person on the planet and answer any question imaginable, but what good is that if you're buried under notifications from apps you forgot you even installed? People know how to open apps, send messages, and scroll endlessly, but they rarely understand the settings, features, and tools that could make their lives easier. Taking the time to learn these skills transforms a user from a passive consumer to an active administrator of their digital world. The user stops feeling controlled by their device and starts feeling empowered. This empowerment is the heart of technological literacy. It transforms technology from something overwhelming into something useful and enjoyable. Once you unlock this level and understand how to use technology as the creator intended it to be used, you will wonder how you ever lived without this understanding. This

understanding won't just make your devices work better for you; it can also have a real financial impact on your life.

In a world where 81% of all American voters say that financial worries are their top concern, it goes without saying that trying to save money should be a priority. Technological literacy directly addresses this concern. Many people replace their phones, tablets, and laptops far more often than necessary because they lack basic maintenance skills. A slow or glitchy device can often lead users to assume that it is "broken" and needs replacing, when in reality a few minutes of troubleshooting can often make the device run like it was brand new. Spending \$1000 to replace a device that requires fifteen minutes worth of maintenance isn't just illogical, it's downright irresponsible. In an almost equally inefficient approach, some people choose to take their devices in to be repaired by professionals only to be charged exorbitant prices for simple services. Best Buy's famous Geek Squad charges \$149.99 for virus removal, something that can often be achieved by simply downloading a program and running it. They charge \$404.99 to backup 500GB of data! Someone with even a basic understanding of how their operating system's file explorer works could achieve this by simply plugging the backup drive into their machine and dragging the files over to it. It might take a while for the files to transfer, but the act of initializing the backup could be achieved in less than two minutes. These terms and concepts might sound confusing, but there is a bright spot here, if you can get to the level where these terms make sense, then not only can you save money, but you could be making it as well.

What if I told you that you could sit in a comfy chair in an air-conditioned office, press a few buttons on your keyboard every hour and achieve total financial security by doing so? It may sound hard to believe, but this is a reality that many tech-savvy workers experience every day.

"The median annual wage for [information technology occupations] was \$105,990 in May 2024, which was higher than the median annual wage for all occupations of \$49,500" (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2023).

People who are concerned about their financial situation are rarely in dire straits when they have tech skills. There is a constant demand for workers with a strong technological understanding, and since tech is constantly evolving, those who evolve with it will be the most sought-after workers on the market. The rise of Artificial Intelligence has spooked many people about the future of employment, but having the ability to interact with artificial intelligence at a high level is actually the most in-demand job skill in the market right now. (Moran, 2026) Even non-technology focused employment is looking to hire workers who have AI skills.

“AI skills significantly increase interview invitation probabilities by approximately 8 to 15 percentage points” (Stephany et al., 2026).

AI is not just a tech tool; it is quite literally reshaping the entire job market. People can worry about robot workers replacing them all they want, but the truth is AI is not going to replace people; people who know how to use AI are going to replace people.

Technological literacy is no longer an optional hobby reserved for geeks and gamers; it is a necessary and highly beneficial skill that can dramatically improve nearly every aspect of modern life. It improves people’s quality of life by making their devices work better, it saves money by preventing unnecessary repairs and replacements, and it opens the door to real economic opportunity. In a world where AI skills are rapidly becoming the most sought-after qualifications in the job market, those who understand how to properly harness the power of modern technology are the ones who will thrive. Ask yourself one final question: if your smartphone has improved your quality of life more than anything, why would you settle for only using a fraction of what it is capable of?

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Revision Reflection

I focused on trying to improve the flow of the essay. I did everything in the peer review guidelines. The MEAT was there. The rhetoric was present and accounted for. It just didn't... flow. There were a lot of stopper words. "In conclusion," breaks the flow and sounds amateurish. The reader should know this is the conclusion because I am summarizing and ending the paper. The professor offered good advice. Read my paper out loud. Watch for the points where I get jammed up. "What good is a device that can access the wealth of all human knowledge and allow instant global wide communication if a user is busy sifting through notifications from applications they haven't used in a year?" turns into "A smartphone can connect you to every person on the planet and answer any question imaginable, but what good is that if you're buried under notifications from apps you forgot you even installed?" I like it better because it's not as wordy, still gets the point across, and asks the question at the end. Esra, who reviewed my paper, said something similar. I really tried to focus on making a lot of my sentences more concise and to the point.

The writing center was a huge help, again. Honestly, anyone in this class who doesn't utilize that resource is just dumb. I was ignorant before, I didn't even know the thing existed, but after we had an assignment that required us to use it, I saw the light. They helped me pick out specific sections where I was being too wordy. Even if I didn't use their suggested replacements, I still focused on those areas because they were totally right. I had a lot of wordy transitions that just kind of broke the flow of the paper. They really helped me to focus on those. They also threw a lot of great punctuation advice my way. Stuff that even word missed but was grammatically correct and helped to improve the flow.

I remember writing the paper and thinking that my ending was pretty weak before I even turned it in. The writing center picked up on that. They suggested I ask another question at the end, and I thought that was a great idea. I toyed around with a few different ideas. I wanted to go doom and gloom or insulting but I decided to try and tie the whole thing together with a question about smartphones. I think that helped give the essay a bit of finality.

Another great thing the writing center said was that they had no idea what I was talking about when I was spitting out tech jargon in the second main body point. That was really helpful. I tried to add a line addressing that and I think it worked out well.

Overall, I thought the paper turned out pretty well. I am actually going to include it in my real portfolio.

Persuasive Essay Peer Review Guidelines

- Analysis and Organization: Does the author offer an introductory paragraph that gives the reader grounding in the author's topic? **Yes**
- Purpose/Thesis: Identify the thesis statement/argument/claim in the author's paper and please write it down. **This is why, now more than ever, becoming technologically literate can profoundly improve your quality of life; it helps you make your technology work better for you, it saves you money, and it can even create opportunities to earn money as well.**
- Purpose/Thesis: Does the author provide reasons to support their claim? Please write down the reasons. **Yes. it helps you make your technology work better for you, it saves you money, and it can even create opportunities to earn money as well.**
- Organization: Does the author's thesis statement provide a "map" for the reader? How so? **Yes. It tells the reasons in the thesis sentence.**
- Organization: Examine each of the author's body paragraphs. Do the paragraphs follow the "MEAT" model (Main idea [aka topic sentence]; Evidence; Analysis of how the evidence supports the main idea; Transition)? **Yes.**
- Evidence: What kind of evidence does the author use? **Personal, studies, and facts**
- Analysis: Who is the author's primary audience? **Everyone**
- Analysis: What appeals does the author use? **Kairos, pathos, ethos, logos**
- Organization: Do you see transitions between paragraphs? **Yes**
- Organization: Does the author provide a succinct conclusion? Keep in mind that we should never offer new evidence in a conclusion, as that leads the reader to believe the argument is not yet complete. Indicate if the author mistakenly gives new evidence in the conclusion. **Yes**
- Organization/Thesis: Evaluate the author's essay for logical organization. Do the paragraphs flow logically, from one to the next? If not, please let the author know that the reader may have trouble following the author's argument flow. **Yes**

